accounts"—bank accounts used to park money earned through fraudulent activity—where the account holder is either duped into letting criminals use their account or is a willing participant. In the region around Deeg, traditional sex work had scaled up to modern trafficking of women; so the transition to online sextortion scams too was smooth. Recent arrests reveal how much more sophisticated and daring operations have become.

A METICULOUS CRACKDOWN

In early August, Prakash received a tip-off from the Intelligence Bureau regarding a threat issued to Prime Minister Narendra Modi. A suspect who had threatened to kill the PM on Instagram was in touch with two persons, Rahul and Sakir Meo, whose cellphone locations were in Deeg. The duo was arrested, and confessed to something else altogether—of posing as arms traders on social media to cheat would-be buyers. On August 23, police in Pahadi (Deeg) arrested four youths and a minor with 14 country-made guns and 24 cartridges which they had put on sale on social media, aiming to commit fraud.

Meanwhile another kind of scam came to light with the arrest of Khalid, Raju and Rahul. The three were part of a gang that offered a "reward" of Rs 25 lakh for impregnating "an unfortunate childless woman". At least 20 gullible men fell for the ruse and deposited Rs 25,000 each as "registration fees". To lure the men, fraudsters had posted pictures of a woman on their social media accounts and even took thousands of rupees as "advance GST" for a "minimum reward" of a few lakh rupees—payable for merely trying to impregnate the woman—which they said they had transferred by sending fake messages.

Another arrest—of Saad and five others—led police to a gang that specialised in luring victims through advertisements for flats on rent in metros. Twenty-nine mobile phone sets and seven SIMs—activated through stolen/ forged identities and linked to bank accounts where illegal money was transferred—were recovered from them. The entire gang was found to have been involved in 5,447 cases, with frauds amounting to Rs 20.31 crore. There were 5,620 complaints against the phone numbers traced to this gang, resulting in 197 FIRs with the National Cyber Crime Reporting Portal.

How far the web has spread was proved with the arrest of Meena, 40, a resident of Barpeta district in Assam. She had befriended and married Ali Mohammad, alias Jhabbu, of Gaondi village in Deeg some years ago, and begun sourcing fake/ forged SIM cards from Assam. After eluding the police for three years, she was arrested finally in May and reportedly confessed to selling 10,000 SIMs—mostly to criminals enabling cyber fraud—for Rs 2,000-5,000 each, earning about Rs 1 crore.

Among the most alarming developments the police found was that adolescents were taking over the operation as the experienced hands fell to the police net. And since the Juvenile Act hands light punishment to minors, they are a handy resource for fraudsters. On August 7, the police detained a 13-year-old boy in Deeg who had been blackmailing Suresh Chaurasia, a school teacher in Chhindwara, Madhya Pradesh, by threatening to make public a sex reel and chat, so much so that the elderly person was driven to suicide in June. Next, the youngster impersonated a cybercrime official and demanded money from the family till the police zeroed in on him and ended his nefarious business. There are 15 more minors that the police have arrested, several of them experts in online fraud.

Prakash and his men also found evidence of close links between the cybercriminals of Jamtara, Deeg and other parts of Mewat. There was, in fact, an exchange



743
CYBER CRIMINALS ARRESTED IN OPERATION ANTI VIRUS IN DEEG DISTRICT FROM FEB. 29 TO JULY 31

189
TOTAL NUMBER OF FIRs REGISTERED AGAINST CRIMINALS



"How we cracked down on cybercrime in Deeg can easily be replicated elsewhere"

RAHUL PRAKASH
Inspector General, Bharatpur Range, Rajasthan